

ATLAS BODYWORK

HEADACHES

Can Massage Therapy Help Chronic Tension Headaches and Migraines?



Ben Vachon, LMT

Massage therapy is a well-established non-invasive physical treatment for reducing the pain of **chronic headaches**. A growing body of clinical research shows that hands-on techniques applied to the neck, head, and body can lower the frequency, duration, and severity of both **tension-type headaches** and **migraines**. Massage works best not as a one-time cure but as a regular, ongoing part of a broader management plan that also addresses the stress, sleep, and lifestyle factors that drive headaches toward chronicity.

WHAT ARE CHRONIC HEADACHES?

The chronic headache is not a single condition but a broad, heterogeneous group of disorders whose shared feature is their persistence. Clinically, the term chronic daily headache is used for headaches that occur on fifteen or more days of the month. Chronic headaches afflict an estimated four to five percent of the population. The most frequent type seen in the general population is the tension-type headache, followed by the chronic and transformed forms of migraine. The pain experienced ranges from a dull, pressing, band-like ache typical in tension-type headaches to a throbbing, often one-sided pain consistent with migraines, and for many sufferers it becomes frequent enough to interfere seriously with work, sleep, and quality of life.¹

Pain

Because pain is inherently subjective, *headache research depends on self-reported measures* to track it. Studies typically ask clients to record the frequency, duration, and intensity of their headaches and to rate a given episode on a subjective visual or verbal analog scale running from no pain to the worst pain imaginable.²

Pain has physiological and psychological origins that are difficult to separate. Chronic headaches are increasingly understood as the product of a nervous system that has progressively become more wired to generate pain rather than as a simple reaction to a local problem. Alongside that physiology, anxiety, depression, and troubled sleep are frequently associated with chronic headaches. These psychological factors do not mean the pain is imagined, rather they aggravate the underlying biology, *each worsening the other* in a feedback loop.¹

Migraines

Not every chronic headache is a migraine. Migraines are a specific primary headache disorder, classically involving throbbing pain accompanied by symptoms such as nausea and sensitivity to light and sound. Chronic tension-type headaches, by contrast, tend to be a more diffuse pressing

pain, often felt across the back of the head and neck. The two conditions share some of the same sensitized machinery and can both respond to hands-on treatment, but they differ in their triggers, their medication strategies, and the way progress is best tracked. Treatment, therefore is most effective when it's matched to the specific headache type rather than applied generically.¹

Pathology

Different mechanisms contribute to chronic headaches, but a central theme is oversensitization of the pain-processing system. The nervous system can become hyper-responsive, reacting to stimuli that would not normally hurt, and responding across a wider area than usual. In tension-type headache, this central sensitization is driven substantially by sustained input from the myofascial tissues of the head, neck, and shoulders. The hardness and tenderness of these muscles appear to feed the process, which is one reason that treatments which address muscular tension (like massage) are so ubiquitous. Migraines involve sensitization of the **trigeminal pain pathway**, leading to a lower threshold for pain and sometimes producing oversensitivity of the skin around the head.¹

Longer-term, frequent headaches may also eventually leave a physical footprint in the brain's own pain-control structures. Imaging work has suggested that repeated migraine attacks are associated with changes in the **periaqueductal grey matter**, a region involved in regulating pain, indicating a role for these central structures in how headaches become chronic.¹

HOW ARE CHRONIC HEADACHES TREATED?

Headaches are treated and managed effectively by a few conservative, nonsurgical measures. Massage therapy, medication, and behavioral change each play a role, and because chronic headaches are rarely traceable to one simple cause, the most durable results usually come from combining them rather than leaning on any single approach.

Medication

For many, medication is the first line of defense against headaches. Over-the-counter analgesics are widely used for easy relief, while migraines in particular are often treated with prescription drugs such as triptans and ergots. Taken too frequently, *acute headache drugs can begin to cause headaches rather than relieve them.* This **medication-overuse, or "rebound," headache** is a common feature across all types of chronic daily headache, and analgesics, ergots, triptans, and opioids can all contribute to it.¹

Massage Therapy

Clinical evidence supports massage as a headache treatment, and the research spans both major headache types. For chronic tension-type headaches, deep tissue relaxation massage of the neck and shoulder muscles significantly reduces both how often headaches occur and for how long. Because tension-type headaches are fed by sustained tension in exactly these myofascial tissues, addressing the neck and shoulder muscles treats a potential driver of the problem rather than its symptoms.²

In one limited study of migraine sufferers, even a single session of massage and gentle neck and spine manipulation has been shown to produce a significant reduction in the pain of a current, active migraine, possibly due to the release of endorphins.³

In all cases, a *regular steady schedule of treatment* tends to serve headache sufferers far better than occasional, reactive sessions.

Behavioral Corrections

Habitual exercise reduces muscle tension and headache frequency. Clinical evidence shows that **strength training** can lower migraine frequency better than some standard preventive medications. Neck and postural strengthening, flexibility work, and mindful self-management of **ergonomics** paired with usual care has been shown to reduce headache frequency, duration, and intensity.⁴

Addressing the anxiety, depression, and poor sleep that often accompanies chronic headaches directly with **cognitive behavioral therapy** targeting the stress responses and unhelpful pain-related thought patterns has been shown across multiple trials to reduce headache frequency and disability. This treatment is particularly useful for chronic and medication-overuse headaches. Relaxation techniques like diaphragmatic breathing, progressive muscle relaxation, guided imagery work along a related path, dialing down the body's stress response, easing **pericranial muscle** tension, and lowering stress-related **cortisol**, which makes them especially helpful for stress-triggered headaches.⁴

WHAT CAN ATLAS BODYWORK DO?

Atlas Bodywork approaches chronic headaches by addressing the muscular tension, movement patterns, and stress-related factors that often contribute to headache frequency and severity. Treatment focuses on the neck, shoulders, jaw, and upper back, while also helping clients build sustainable habits that support long-term improvement.

References

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